

CBT THOUGHT DIARY

A 7-Day Thought Record Worksheet

Identify -> Examine -> Reframe your thoughts

Includes a fully worked ANGER example

What is a Thought Diary?

A thought diary (also called a Thought Record) is the core self-monitoring tool of Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT). CBT is built on the idea that it is not events themselves that directly cause our feelings and behaviour, but the THOUGHTS and INTERPRETATIONS we have about those events. The same situation can lead to very different emotions depending on what we tell ourselves about it.

When we are distressed, fast, automatic thoughts pop into the mind. These 'automatic thoughts' often feel true, but they are frequently biased, exaggerated, or unhelpful. The thought diary slows this process down so you can catch a thought, look at the evidence for and against it, and replace it with a more balanced, realistic view. Over time this changes how you feel and act.

Why use it?

- It makes invisible, automatic thinking visible and easier to question.
- It breaks the loop where Situation -> Thought -> strong Emotion -> unhelpful Behaviour.
- It builds the skill of responding rather than reacting - especially useful for anger, anxiety and low mood.
- It gives you a written record so you can spot recurring thinking patterns over the week.

The CBT model in one line

Situation -> Automatic Thought -> Emotion -> Behaviour / Body reaction

The thought diary lets you step into the arrow between Thought and Emotion - the one place where change is possible.

Based on established CBT sources

J. S. Beck - Cognitive Behavior Therapy: Basics & Beyond | Greenberger & Padesky - Mind Over Mood
Hawton et al. - Cognitive Behaviour Therapy for Psychiatric Problems (Oxford Medical Publications)

The 7 Columns - and what each one means

Fill them left to right. This is the heart of the thought diary.

1. Situation / Trigger

What happened? Where, when, who with, what were you doing? Write the plain facts only - like a camera would record them. No opinions or interpretations here.

Example (anger): 'At 6 pm my colleague took credit for my report in the team meeting.'

2. Emotions (rate 0-100%)

Name the feeling in one word (angry, hurt, anxious, ashamed) and rate its intensity from 0 to 100%. Rating helps you notice change later. You can list more than one emotion.

Example: Angry 90%, Humiliated 60%.

3. Automatic Thoughts

The exact words, images or beliefs that flashed through your mind in that moment. Ask: 'What was going through my mind just then?' Circle the 'hot thought' - the one most linked to the strongest emotion.

Example: 'He deliberately disrespected me. He always steals my work. I can't let people walk over me.'

4. Evidence FOR the hot thought

Facts (not opinions) that support the hot thought being true. Being honest here keeps the exercise fair and believable.

Example: 'He did say the idea was his. He didn't mention my name.'

5. Evidence AGAINST the hot thought

Facts that do not fit the hot thought, or that another person might point out. This is where you widen the lens and challenge the bias.

Example: 'The manager knows I wrote it. He may have been nervous and rushed. He has credited me before.'

6. Balanced / Alternative Thought

A fairer, more realistic thought that takes BOTH columns of evidence into account. It is not forced positive thinking - it is accurate thinking. Rate how much you believe it (0-100%).

Example: 'It was frustrating and I can raise it calmly with him. One meeting doesn't mean he always steals my work.' (Believe 75%)

7. Re-rate Emotion & Outcome

Re-rate the original emotion now (0-100%) and note what you will do differently. A drop in intensity shows the reframe is working.

Example: Angry now 40%. Action: 'Speak to him privately tomorrow and email the manager the original draft.'

Worked Example: An Anger Situation

How the diary transforms a hot, angry reaction into a balanced response.

Read this completed row before filling your own. Notice how the emotion drops from 90% to 40% once the hot thought is examined against real evidence.

1. Situation	2. Emotion (0-100%)	3. Automatic thoughts (hot thought *)	4. Evidence FOR	5. Evidence AGAINST	6. Balanced thought (believe %)	7. Re-rate + action
At 6 pm, in the team meeting, my colleague presented my report as his own idea.	Angry 90% Humiliated 60%	* He deliberately disrespected me. He always steals my work. I can't let anyone walk over me.	He said the idea was his. He did not mention my name.	The manager knows I wrote it. He looked nervous and rushed. He has credited me before. 'Always' is an exaggeration.	It was frustrating and unfair, and I can calmly raise it with him. One meeting does not mean he always steals my work. (Believe 75%)	Angry now 40%. Action: speak to him privately tomorrow; email manager the original draft.

What this example teaches

- The 'hot thought' contained thinking traps: mind-reading ('deliberately'), over-generalising ('always'), and an all-or-nothing rule ('walk over me').
- Looking for evidence AGAINST did not deny the problem - it made the view accurate and less explosive.
- The balanced thought still allows action (a calm conversation) but removes the fuel for aggression.
- The measurable drop in anger (90% -> 40%) is the proof the technique worked.

7-Day Thought Diary - Worksheet

One row per day. Fill it in as close to the event as you can.

Tip: rate emotions 0-100%% in column 2, circle the hot thought in column 3, then re-rate in column 7 to see your progress.

Day / Date	Situation (facts)	Emotion 0-100%	Automatic thought (*hot)	Evidence FOR	Evidence AGAINST	Balanced thought (believe %)	Re-rate + action
Day 1 ____/____							
Day 2 ____/____							
Day 3 ____/____							
Day 4 ____/____							

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Day / Date	Situation (facts)	Emotion 0-100%	Automatic thought (*hot)	Evidence FOR	Evidence AGAINST	Balanced thought (believe %)	Re-rate + action
Day 5 ____/____							
Day 6 ____/____							
Day 7 ____/____							

End-of-week reflection

Which thinking traps showed up most this week (e.g. mind-reading, all-or-nothing, over-generalising)?

Which situations triggered the strongest anger, and what did they have in common?

Which balanced thought helped the most - and how much did my emotion drop?

One thing I will try differently next week: